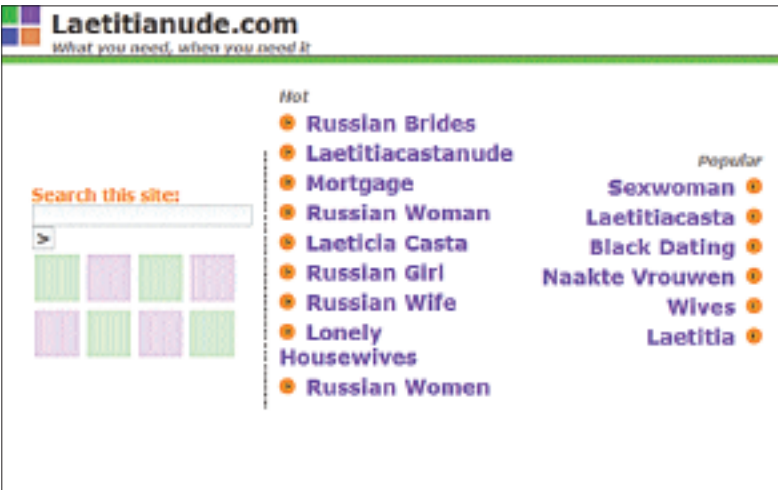




Looks good, the categorisation...



Not quite what we were looking for

word “tips” on several pages and clustered those together.

But then, when you do a Laetitia Casta at Clusty, you get (apart from the main results) clusters such as Wallpaper, Model, and so on—which can be useful. Similarly with “Nokia N90”: clusters such as Nokia N91, Specs & Features, Carl Zeiss, and more. But the real value of clusters becomes apparent when you do a search on “nanotechnology”: the clusters are Research, Investment, Future, Applications, and so on.

Clusters, then, get more and more useful as you know less and less about what you’re searching for. There are other clustering search engines as well—Lexxe, for example.

Community

Now community search is indeed Search 2.0. Take a look at Rollyo (<http://rollyo.com>). Anyone can “create a search engine” here for other people to use. So if your subject of interest is nanobots, you give your “Searchroll” a name, and manually enter the sites you think are the most valuable sources of information on nanobots. Submit that to the site, and when someone wants to do a search on nanobots, he or she might “explore” the Searchrolls and come upon yours—and use it.

If this becomes a big thing, it’ll become the next big thing... the idea is, the community is better than any search engine spider at removing the junk and the not-so-useful from the search results. But for a community search site to grow in value, there must be a sufficient number of people willing to actually use it—beta-testers, so to speak.

Straight Questions

Alternatives apart, let’s ask: how good are each of the big three—Google, Yahoo!, and Live Search—at bringing you what you’d like to see? Let’s also bring Ask.com into the comparison, because many claim it brings up the most relevant, though fewer, results.

We’ll speak about plain text Web search, because areas like image search are too subjective. So say we have a simple question, the same one we used earlier: “How do search engines work?”

No surprises here. For a straightforward, Internet-related query like this one, down to 50 results, the first three all bring up totally relevant matches, many of which actually include the original phrase. Interestingly, Ask.com brought up the following in the first 50, something we wouldn’t say is relevant:

“Daily news about search engines and the search engine industry, and information on using search engines to market your web site...”

But to its credit, Ask brings up queries that can help narrow down the search: “Most popular search engines,” “How are search engines used,” and more.

Idle Surfing

Next up: “latest Bollywood movie,” which you might type in if you’re just beginning a surfing session with no particular goal in mind, hoping for something entertaining. All three brought up pretty much what we expected—stuff on movies, wallpapers, gossip, actors and actresses, and all the rest. But there’s an important point here: Yahoo! gives “newcomers”—upcoming sites and personal sites, that is—a larger chance than do the others. This might be a good or a bad thing, depending on how far down the results you go: you don’t want an obscure site coming up in the first ten matches, and at the same time, if you’re looking beyond that, you might like a little change. This is also why you’ll see your own home page climb Yahoo!’s ranks before it Google’s. The moral: give Yahoo! a chance if you want to give lesser-known sites a chance.

Research

Now, say you’re doing research into a subject as part of college work—nanowires, for exam-

ple: their applications, the future, and so on. You really don’t know what to expect; after all, you don’t know anything about the subject, and it’s the duty of the search engine to take you in the right direction. What do they bring up?

The first ten results, though different at the three sites, are all relevant. However, beyond about 20 or 30, the results at Yahoo! tend to get a little niche—as in advanced. Even so, Yahoo! gives you a suggestion starting with “Also try:”. In this particular case, it’s about memory and nanowires, which is pretty good.

But here’s a surprise: Live Search produced what seemed to us the most interesting results in the top 50. It’s not strictly about relevance here—most of the results on all three are relevant—but as a starting point for further research, Live Search served better.

Random Interest

If you happened to read something in the newspapers and you’re interested in finding more—say, “Darfur”—it’s again the first ten results that are important, because you’re unlikely to go beyond those.

With such an example—an issue of international concern—there’s not much scope for going wrong, and none did. However, Yahoo! and MSN have their versions of other searches you could try, which Google doesn’t.

Divining Intent

This shouldn’t really be called “the real test,” because it’s not often we do searches like this one. How do you pronounce “Laetitia”? We used the keywords “pronounce Laetitia”, and Google gave us the answer within the first ten results. Neither Yahoo! nor MSN could. That’s probably because the Google results with the answer had the word “pronounced” instead of “pronounce”, and Google sort of treats those two the same.

This is only one example, but it wouldn’t be wrong to say that when you deviate from “normal” searches—when you throw something a little obscure at the search engines—Google probably divines your intent best.

And So...?

Yes, some search engine will “perform” better in one instance, and some other in another instance. There absolutely cannot be something like a “ranking” for search engines across all categories. But we have three lessons:

(a) Take a look at the table *Quick Shots*. The comments indicate what we want to say, and note that Google really is the best—but not by too huge a margin. Note that the results were *different* in most cases. The search engines aren’t all the same.

(b) Don’t write the other major search engines off; don’t say Google is all you need. Especially when you’re doing serious research on any topic, take a look at all of them. At the same time,

(c) If you’re trying to find something that is unlikely to be spelt out on a Web page, Google is probably your best bet. ■

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Quick Shots

Category	Search Phrase—Without Quotes	Comments On Question	Google			Yahoo!			Live Search			Our Comments
			Dud	Average	Good	Dud	Average	Good	Dud	Average	Good	
Computer Utility	Motorcycle wallpapers	We all love our bikes!	6	3	1	8	1	1	5	4	1	We expected many duds here, and one could have used an image search for this one—but how did the text search fare?
Software Search	Alarm clock software	Self-explanatory	0	8	2	4	4	2	1	6	3	We didn’t actually test the software we found; we went by what we’d expect based on our surfing experience. In addition, trialware has been classified as “average.”
Web site Search	Latest technology news	To keep yourself updated	2	4	4	1	7	2	4	4	2	A “dud” here means something that really isn’t mainstream. Strict ratings here!
Shopping Comparison	Creative Altec Lansing	Trying to compare two brands without messing around with the keywords	3	6	1	6	4	0	7	2	1	“Average” here means the result page gives some information about both brands. “Dud” also means the word “creative” is used as a word instead of the brand, and if one of the brands is left out. “Good” is only if both brands appear on the same page. Also, we were looking for speakers!
Planning Travel	Rajasthan holiday	Starting point for planning a holiday	2	6	2	2	8	0	3	5	2	Points awarded for instant booking possibilities and for more information.
Computer Problem	Task manager has been disabled	You have a virus, and it says “Task Manager has been disabled by your administrator”	0	0	10	0	0	10	3	0	7	“Good” means all result pages that tell you something about the problem
General Interest	History of British India	For students	5	5	0	7	3	0	6	4	0	A subjective rating of content
Technology Information	HDMI	You need information on that tech term you heard	3	2	5	3	2	5	8	0	2	This one checks if you get the information you need, without unnecessary data
Random Question	What is life all about?	Don’t we all want to know?	7	1	2	6	2	2	10	0	0	Subjective; does the result attempt to answer the question?